

After the dinner, Lucky offered to drop Mouse home. I thought Mouse would decline the offer out of civility since Lucky would have to go out of his way to drop him. To my irritation, Mouse agreed.

The next day, I called up Mouse at his residence and apologized for being a bit brusque with him the previous evening. Mouse said he did not feel offended and was in fact worried if he had blurted out something unwittingly. For the next couple of weeks, I was regularly in touch with Mouse, and he passed on the information I sought from him.

He then suddenly stopped taking my calls. This went on for a few days. I suspected that he had switched his loyalty to Lucky. Finally, when I managed to get him on the phone that weekend, I gave vent to my anger and accused him of deceit.

Mouse heard me out patiently and then said: 'Fair enough, Lala, but you have been exploiting me all this while by giving me a pittance for such valuable information. I am now getting ten times what you pay me every month. I can help you out once in a while for old times' sake, but don't expect me to be at your beck and call.'

I was furious. 'So you have sold yourself out to Lucky,' I railed.

'You can think what you like,' he replied calmly.

'I am going to write a letter to your seniors and inform them about your side business,' I said.

'Do so by all means. But that would mean implicating yourself as well. Even if that does not happen, you may still end up making some powerful enemies,' he said, and hung up.

I had played my final card, and lost. I had no doubt that Mouse was now taking orders from Lucky. I was mad at being cheated out of a source of precious information. That evening I dialled Lucky and gave him a piece of my mind.

'B*\$#c@%d, M@#%*\$d, you call me a friend, talk about trust, and is this how you honour friendship? By stabbing me in the back?' I yelled at him.

'Calm down now, Lala, what's the matter?' he asked.

That made me angrier, and I abused him some more. He still kept his cool.

He then rang me a couple of days later. I ignored him.

Lucky persisted. Finally, I answered his call.